

you would need from your in-car system. The top-of-the-line unit in our car is a part of Kia's optional package, using an 8-inch infotainment display with integrated navigation, FM radio, multiple input ports and Apple CarPlay/Android Auto. Things work fairly smoothly, although the interface itself is not too intuitive.

You use a combination of physical buttons placed below the air conditioning vents to switch between different windows of the screen, and even though the buttons are placed ergonomically and provide a satisfyingly 'clicky' feedback, there is a bit of a disconnect in not being able to simply tap on a home screen on the touch-enabled display to switch between screens. The screen is also placed a bit far away from the driver's mean position of sitting, which makes you use the buttons more often than not. The interface itself is a bit dull in terms of its colour scheme, and while it is likely that Kia's Indian cars will feature the same infotainment unit, the company will do well to tweak

- **Price:** NA
- **Powertrain:** 2.0-litre, Gasoline direct injection, 202 bhp, 375 Nm, Front-wheel drive, Six-speed automatic
- **Fuel economy:** 8.9 kmpl (obtained)
- **Pros:** Looks brilliant, Sophisticated interiors, Spacious and comfortable, Loaded with features, Great ride comfort, Easy to drive
- **Cons:** Not the most engaging to drive, Heavy on fuel consumption, Slightly slow to overtake

in Hyundai's cars. The backlight on the semi-analogue dials and digits are controllable, thereby giving you the freedom to choose the intensity of light in the dials.

The front seats are power adjustable, giving a wide range of control over your seating position. You also get adjustable lumbar setting for the driver, along with seat heating and cooling for the front two seats, a heated leather

steering wheel, cruise control, speed limiter, two-zone automatic climate control, a clean air filter, memory seat settings, electronic parking brake with auto-hold, adaptive parking sensors with a dynamic rear parking camera, auto-dimming mirrors, two AC vents for the rear passengers, and a panoramic glass roof with electronically-operable panoramic roof sheath and sunroof. All the AC vents also get their own fan intensity control, and there are integrated reading light-and-coat hanger modules to the rear, hence making it a complete executive sedan package.

DRIVE AND RIDE QUALITY

The Kia Optima is a long car, measuring almost 4.9 metres in length. Add to that its 2.2 tonne body weight, and this makes for a car that has substantial footprint on road. The long wheelbase format of the Optima gives plenty of space inside - even with the seat pushed substantially back for my 5'11" frame, there was always ample knee and feet room for the rear passenger. That said, you do feel the heft and length of the car at times, particularly in the congested, narrow Delhi lanes. More often than not, the parking sensors would alert you sharply owing to being too near an obstacle.

That said, handling and manoeuvring the Kia Optima is a fairly easy task. The steering wheel is light and easy to turn, and still fairly precise. It does not provide the best amount of feedback, which will be a deterrent if you are an enthusiastic driver and like engaging steering wheel feedback. Nevertheless,

it is a breeze to drive in the city, with the six-speed automatic transmission doing its duty flawlessly. In 'sport' drive mode, the Optima is not a particularly eager car to lunge forward, and instead flows along smoothly on smooth pitch with speed building up steadily. While it really works well in the city and even when you are cruising along on highways at triple-digit speeds, it can be a bit of a bother to make overtakes.

Fortunately, the 2018 Kia Optima comes with paddle shifters, which allows you to switch the gearbox to manual control. This makes the car noticeably faster, of course, although its heft still does not make it feel uber-fast. The 2.0-litre direct injection gasoline engine produces 202 bhp and an impressive 375 Nm torque, and while this amount of power and torque means the car does not feel slow, there is a surprising sluggish nature to it. The Optima also consumes a fair amount of fuel - the consumption figures varied between 6.1 kmpl in peak city traffic, 12.2 kmpl in open roads and registering average of 8.9 kmpl.

In terms of ride quality, the 2018 Kia Optima is an excellent performer. The suspension is a bit on the softer side, which makes city ride quality absolutely sublime. It also holds its ground well in well-laid out highways, so there is no trace of the floatiness that soft suspensions may induce.

THE WAY FORWARD

Unfortunately, the 2018 Kia Optima only serves as an indicator for the brand's potential right now. When Kia launches its first cars in 2019, the focus is solely going to be on mainstream options like compact SUVs and premium hatchbacks. Cars like the Optima will probably feature in India too, but at a later date.

And yet, we cannot help but be super excited about the potential that the Kia Optima represents. If Kia manages to bring at least half the goodness of quality, assurance, refinement and opulence with its cars in India, the brand stands a chance of being a winner in the long run. After our privileged pre-launch test drive of the Kia Optima over about 500 kilometres and four days, we've come back really impressed, and even more excited about it. 



the overall interface a bit to make it more engaging on overall terms.

The Kia Optima in India does not come with the radar-based driver assistance units that is available in North America, and that is also a possible indicator of the fact that these advanced systems will probably not feature in Kia's Indian cars, even when they begin rolling out the more expensive models. In terms of other electronics, though, the Kia Optima acs the charts. The instrument cluster is semi-digital, with a highly useful central multi-information display that is similar to what you'd see